

Abstract

Over the years, I have had many unsuccessful experiences in awards, publications, grants, internships, job applications, etc. Inspired by Dr. Jessica Vitak's CV of Failure, I am also documenting my experiences. I hope my CV of Failure can help young researchers and make their lives a little easier. Please note that this is by no means a comprehensive list. (Last update: 5/10/2026)

Key Spirit: Failure is a necessary part of the academic journey. When you encounter failure, keep calm and carry on.

Who Am I?

Assistant Professor, Computer Science, Johns Hopkins University	July 2025–Now
Assistant Professor, Computer Science, Virginia Tech	August 2023–June 2025
Assistant Professor, Information Systems, UMBC	Jan 2021–July 2023
Post-Doctoral Fellow, CyLab, Carnegie Mellon University	Jan 2020–Dec 2020

Education Background

Ph.D. in Information Sciences, Syracuse University	2020
M.S. in Information Management, University of Washington	2014
B.S. in Business Administration, Harbin Institute of Technology	2012

Fun Facts about Me

- As you can see above, I do not have a Computer Science (CS) background or degree, yet I work as a professor in CS.
- When I applied to graduate schools, I applied to work in the Natural Language Processing field (which I knew nothing about), and now I work in HCI

Academic Jobs that I Did Not Get

First round of faculty application in 2020, around 40 applications, 4 phone interviews, 4 onsite interviews, 2 offers

- CS, U. of Tennessee (onsite interview, no offer)
- CS, Virginia Tech (onsite interview, no offer)
- A long list of universities that contains nearly all openings on the market (no interview)

Second round of faculty application in 2022, 20 applications, 3 phone interviews, 1 onsite interview, 1 offer

- iSchool, U. of Wisconsin—Madison (phone interview, no onsite)
- iSchool, UNC Chapel Hill (phone interview, no onsite)

Graduate Schools that Rejected Me

I applied to Ph.D. program twice. I did not receive any offers in the first round, so I had to try for a second year and received 1 offer.

First round of application in 2014, 10 out of 10 rejected

- iSchool, University of Washington (I graduated from here)
- HCDE, University of Washington
- CSE, University of Washington
- Hentz College, Carnegie Mellon University
- HCI Institute, Carnegie Mellon University

- iSchool, UC Berkeley
- iSchool, U. of Michigan
- iSchool, Syracuse U.
- iSchool, U. of Maryland, College Park
- iSchool, UNC Chapel Hill

Second round of application in 2015, 4 out of 5 rejected

- iSchool, U. of Washington
- iSchool, U. of Maryland
- iSchool, Rutgers U.
- iSchool, U. of Michigan

Declined Awards and Fellowships

To start with, I am not ever eligible for most of the fellowships and scholarships out there

- SIGCHI Dissertation Award
- John Karat SOUPS Award
- Meta PhD Fellowship (twice)
- Microsoft PhD Fellowship

Rejected Grants

I do not submit a lot of grants, so the list is somewhat short

- NSF Future Core, 2026
- NSF SaTC, 2026
- Amazon Research Award, 2024
- NSF SaTC EDU, 2023
- NSF Eager, 2022
- Mozilla Research Grant, 2021
- NSF, 3 grants at multiple programs, 2025
- Google Academic Research Award, 2025
- Open Philanthropy Research Grant

Rejected or Unpublished Papers

Rejected Industry Job Applications

When I was on the job market, I also applied to several industry research lab positions. All rejected.

- Google UX researcher, research scientists, privacy engineer, software engineer
- Meta UX researcher, research scientists, privacy engineer, software engineer
- Microsoft Research
- IBM Research
- Amazon Research
- Autodesk Research
- Adobe Research
- Apple
- A long list of other large and small companies (nearly 100)

Rejected Internship Applications

I applied four years during my PhD, but did not get any offers for an internship.

- Google UX researcher intern (applied for 4 years, multiple rounds of interviews, all rejected)
- Meta UX researcher intern (applied for 4 years, multiple rounds of interviews, all rejected)
- Microsoft Research intern (applied for 2 years, both rejected)
- IBM Research (applied through collaborator)
- Amazon research intern (applied for 2 years, multiple roles, all rejected)

- Airbnb UX intern
- Adobe UX intern
- Apple research intern
- Oracle research intern
- Expedia research intern
- Bloomberg
- Nike
- Disney
- Internship program at Harvard
- A long list of small companies